

Make The Cost Of Low Autonomy Transparent With Permission Tokens

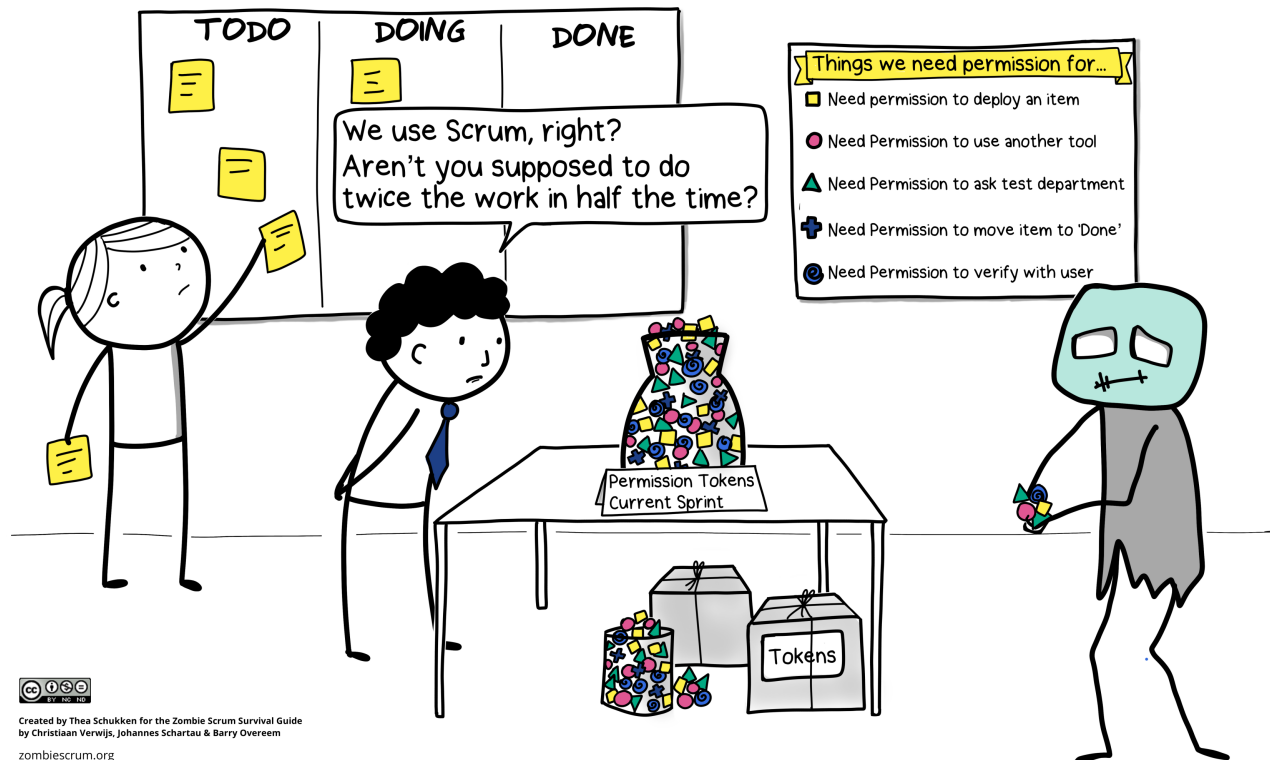
The simple experiment drives continuous learning and increase team autonomy by showing where a lack of autonomy is causing impediments



Purpose Of This Experiment

The autonomy of teams decreases as their dependencies on external people increase. Some dependencies are explicit, such as when a Scrum Team needs someone outside the team to do something for them. Other dependencies are more implicit. Having to ask for permission or approval from someone outside the team in order to proceed is a good example.

This experiment is about making transparent where and how often permission is required.



Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment requires only a jar, some tokens, and a few minutes during your Sprint Review.

Impact On Survival



Even in the most zombified environments, regaining some sense of control makes people sigh with relief.

Steps

To try this experiment, do the following:

1. Find an empty jar, or another container, and place it in the team room. Somewhere near the Sprint Backlog is the best spot.
2. Give everyone on your team a bunch of permission tokens. You can use marbles, LEGO bricks, magnets, or stickies. Use different colors for the various permission categories. For example, the permission to release something, to move an item to another column on your Scrum Board, or to change your tools or environment. We recommend a limit of five categories to keep things simple.
3. During the Sprint, put an approval token in the jar every time someone on the Scrum Team has to ask permission from someone outside the team. For example, put a token in the jar when an external architect needs to approve that an item is done. Or when the Product Owner has to vet an item with an external manager. Put a token in the jar when you need permission from office management to purchase stickies. And put a token in the jar when you need a configuration to be changed by an external administrator. Aside from requests for permission, also add a token every time you need someone outside the team to perform a specific action as well.
4. During the Sprint Review, and with stakeholders present, share the number of tokens in the jar. Ask: "How does this affect our ability to quickly adapt in the moment and do what is the most valuable? Where can we simplify things?" Invite people to first consider this question for themselves and in silence, then in pairs for two minutes, and then paired with another pair for four more minutes. Capture the most salient improvements with the whole group. The Sprint Retrospective is a great opportunity for digging into potential improvements.

Our Findings

- For another perspective, you can use different colors for everyone on your team. This allows you to identify who is most often in need of permission.
- If you want to focus on the amount of organizational bureaucracy, don't add permission tokens for requests from direct stakeholders such as customers, users, or people who otherwise invest significant money or time in your product.
- The experiment "Break the Rules!" that we offer in the book is great to test where asking for permission matters, and where it just gets in the way of doing the right thing.

More Resources

- Whitepaper: [The 8 Stances of a Scrum Master](#) illustrates well why Scrum Masters are responsible for removing certain impediments.
- Research: [How Do Scrum Masters Deal With Problems Outside Of Their Team's Control?](#). Together with [Age of Product](#), we asked Scrum Masters how they overcame impediments (including dependencies).
- Podcast: [Scrum Mythbusters: The Scrum Master Must Resolve Every Problem](#)

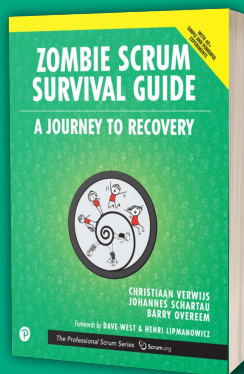
Help Us With Your Feedback



We are eager to learn how this experiment benefitted your team. What did it make possible? How did it help you make progress in your recovery from Zombie Scrum? With your data, we can improve our recommendations to other teams. You can share [your feedback](#) here with us in a only few minutes.



The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide



Zombie Scrum is on the rise! What may look like Scrum from a distance often turns out to be anything but when you take a closer look. Although teams go through the motions of Scrum, Sprints don't result in valuable outcomes, customers are not involved, teams have little autonomy and nobody is doing anything to improve.

A detailed examination of Zombie Scrum

In our book, we share our research and experience in the field with Zombie Scrum. We explore symptoms and causes, and dig deep into why Zombie Scrum usually starts when the purpose of Scrum isn't clear. With our book, the purpose of Scrum was never this clear!

Start your recovery tomorrow

The good news is that recovery is entirely possible. Our book contains over 40 practical experiments to start recovery, even when your organization has succumbed to it completely.

Get your copy now

You can find the 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' in your favorite bookstore starting from November 23, 2020. Or buy your copy from us at zombiescrum.org. The book comes with a free digital first aid kit, and a nice discount for a physical kit.



The Zombie Scrum Resistance

The 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' is written by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schartau and Barry Overeem, and richly illustrated by Thea Schukken.

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